engagements and well-planned rallies in the cities was making the difference. By September 2013, when Modi formally took over as the BJP prime ministerial candidate, a mini wave was already building up in his favour across urban India. The month of Modi's coronation as PM candidate was also the period when the rupee plunged to its lowest level to the dollar, and retail inflation was in double digits. The faltering economy had created an anti-UPA feeling in urban India in particular. Modi symbolized and channelized the anger against the government. 'He was the right man at the right place with the right rhetoric,' is how one senior UPA minister explained the rise of Modi in 2013.

But to win a general election and achieve 'Mission 272-plus', the magic needed to spread well beyond the bright lights of the metros. 'Yes, we had taken elements from a Barack Obama-style presidential campaign, but we needed to innovate and fine-tune it to a diverse country like India,' is how one Modi aide put it.

The findings of a nationwide survey done by Team Modi in the first half of 2013 had slightly worried them. The data showed that while Modi enjoyed instant recall and huge support in towns and cities, there wasn't an immediate connect when it came to rural India. Taking the Modi campaign buzz to rural India was the next big, and even more difficult, challenge for Team Modi. The November–December assembly elections in states with a large rural population like Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh would be a test case. 'We knew we had a hit film in the multiplexes. Now we needed to spread the message to single-screen cinemas in small towns and villages too,' says the Modi aide.

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On 31 October 2013, Modi formally launched the 'Statue of Unity' programme—a project whose stated aim was to build the largest ever statue in the world, a 240-metre bronze statue of Sardar Patel, directly facing the Narmada Dam. The real target was to mobilize people from across India on a 'nationalistic' platform. Modi had been an unabashed admirer of the